

20260927 Mark 4:24-25 "The One Who Has"

Today, let us continue reading the Gospel of Mark.

At the beginning of chapter 4, Jesus told the parable of the sower.

The seed fell in four places:

along the path, on rocky ground, among thorns, and on good soil.

Jesus explained that the seed being sown is the word.

Of those on good soil, he said this:

Mark 4:20 But those sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word, accept it, and bear fruit—thirtyfold, sixtyfold, and a hundredfold.

For those on good soil, it began with hearing. Then, because they accepted the word, they bore abundant fruit.

The people who did not accept it heard it just as they did.

But they did not accept it.

And those who accepted it did not produce the seed themselves.

They heard the word God had sown and received it as something from God.

God is fair and gives his word to everyone alike.

What follows depends on how each person receives it.

After the parable of the sower, last week we heard the parable of the lampstand.

To sum it up:

Where should we put a lamp—under a basket or under a bed?

No. A lamp belongs on a lampstand in the middle of the room.

When people spend a long time in the dark, their eyes gradually adjust.

They can begin to walk by relying on memory, experience, and their senses.

Before long, however, they may even forget that they are in darkness.

That is also a life ruled by our sinful nature.

Such a life will keep losing its way.

That is why Jesus tells us to look to the light of the Word.

The path shown by the Word can sometimes be hard. We may feel unable to follow it by our own reasoning or calculation.

But when we follow that light, we are led to a wonderful place far beyond the outcome we imagined when we counted the costs and benefits.

Are we putting the Word on the lampstand now, at the center of our lives?

Are we letting that light shine into the depths of our hearts and into our homes?

If we search our hearts now and realize that we have hidden the light we were given, that realization is already a great step.

No matter how many times we fail, let us bring out that light again and put the Word back at the center of our lives.

The light of the Word of Jesus Christ shines on our lives and leads us to life that is truly abundant.

After saying these things, Jesus said:

Mark 4:23 If anyone has ears to hear, let him hear.

That was where we left off.

Today's passage comes immediately after this.

Here, too, Jesus speaks about the theme running through chapter 4: hearing the Word.

Mark 4:24 He said to them, "Pay attention to what you hear. The measure you use will be used for you too, and still more will be added to you."

"Pay attention to what you hear."

To put the original wording briefly: "Take care about what you are hearing."

Jesus asks those listening to him what their ears are taking in and how they are receiving it.

First, then, what are we to hear?

Jesus has already shown us.

Mark 4:14 The sower sows the word.

Jesus is sowing the word.

Mark 4:20 But those sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word, accept it, and bear fruit—thirtyfold, sixtyfold, and a hundredfold.

So when he says, "Pay attention to what you hear," what we are to hear is the word of Jesus.

Now let us consider, "Pay attention to what you hear."

How should we take care as we listen to the Word?

When we read the Bible, we may think that we know a story well and skim over it.

Or are we waiting only for words we want to hear?

Are we really listening to what Jesus is actually saying?

Are we opening the Bible only to confirm what we already think?

When we do that, it may seem that we are listening, but we are not listening rightly.

Each of us needs to pay close attention to this.

Am I listening carefully to the words of Scripture? Am I listening only in the way I want to?

Am I nodding along after grasping only the surface?

The Word can certainly be difficult. Yet we can see how important it is to face it, because Jesus himself returns to this question again and again.

Let us pay attention too.

After asking that question, verse 24 speaks of a measure.

It is an illustration of how we are to pay attention.

“The measure you use will be used for you too.”

When we use a measuring instrument, we read the amount from the scale it shows.

An accurate instrument measures accurately, and we can know the amount correctly.

But if its standard is off, it cannot measure the amount correctly.

We cannot recognize the amount for what it really is.

In other words, the measure a person holds changes that person's judgment and understanding.

Jesus uses this picture as he speaks to those who hear him.

Jesus does not say directly what is placed on the scale.

But the command immediately before it is “Pay attention to what you hear.”

So this measure is certainly connected with our attitude as we hear the Word.

Does he mean that the more time we spend reading the Bible, the more understanding we will gain in direct proportion?

No, that is not what he is saying.

We should understand it as a call to keep approaching the Word with the right orientation.

What happens if we hold a faulty measure?

If we think Jesus is of little importance when we listen to him,

we may dismiss his words as being of little importance too.

If we expect him to defeat our enemies by military force, then when Jesus speaks of forgiveness, we may think, “That is not what I wanted to hear.”

If we think Jesus will always speak only gentle words, his stern words will feel out of place.

If we hear him as one god among many, we will miss the most important thing: he is the one true God.

Because what he says differs from what that person expected,
the person fails to receive the importance of his words.

This is what it means that “the measure you use will be used for you too.”

What do we think Jesus is like?

That affects what we ourselves receive.

If we dismiss his words as “nothing more than that,” we miss what is being said.

If we seek only what we want to hear, we fail to receive what Jesus is telling us.

We judge Jesus within limits we have set for ourselves, and receive only that much from the Word.

This is a mistake we could make even without meaning to.

We need a sound measure: Jesus is all-knowing and all-powerful, the one God and Creator,
and, for that very reason, he truly loves each one of us.

We need to hold firmly to that understanding as we listen to the Word.

But Jesus does not stop there. He says, “And still more will be added to you.”

When we encounter words that do not fit our own thinking,

we can ask, “Why does Jesus say this?” and keep listening.

As we listen that way, we may be taught things beyond what we were seeking at first.

A person who wished to see an enemy defeated hears the command to love that enemy.

It may be hard to accept at first. But as the person keeps listening to Jesus, he or she may learn a way
of relating to others that was never imagined when thinking only of the victory originally desired.

Jesus does not explain here exactly what will be added, or how.

It will probably differ from case to case and come in stages.

Yet he promises those who listen, “Still more will be added to you.”

In other words, it will surely happen.

Let us trust that promise. Instead of listening only through our present ideas, let us keep listening to
the words of Jesus.

That is what it means to “pay attention to what you hear.”

*Mark 4:25 For the one who has will be given more; but the one who has not will lose even
what he has.*

I want us to notice the word “for” at the end of the Japanese translation.

In verse 24, Jesus commanded people to pay attention to what they hear,

and promised that they would be measured by the measure they use, and that still more would be

added.

Verse 25 follows as the reason for this.

Mark 4:24 He said to them, "Pay attention to what you hear. The measure you use will be used for you too, and still more will be added to you."

Mark 4:25 For the one who has will be given more; but the one who has not will lose even what he has.

How we receive what we hear is connected to what we are later given, and to what we lose.

First, what does "the one who has" have?

Jesus has already said this in this chapter:

Mark 4:11 He said to them, "The secret of the kingdom of God has been given to you, but to those outside everything comes in parables."

The disciples, then, have been "given" the secret of the kingdom of God.

Mark 4:20 But those sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word, accept it, and bear fruit—thirtyfold, sixtyfold, and a hundredfold.

And in verse 20, those on good soil hear and accept the word and bear fruit.

In light of these words, I think we can connect "having" in verse 25 with receiving the word given by Jesus.

This is the very secret of a life in which we take the Word to heart as something addressed to us. Those who have it will come to know the Word more deeply and be able to direct their lives in a better way.

The second half, however, contains severe words:

"The one who has not will lose even what he has."

Mark does not write here, "what he thinks he has."

Jesus says that even what he has will be taken away.

Returning to the parable of the sower, this is what is written about those along the path:

Mark 4:15 Those along the path are the people in whom the word is sown. When they hear it, Satan immediately comes and takes away the word sown in them.

The words translated "taken away" in verse 25 and "takes away" in verse 15 use the same verb in the original language.

Those along the path also heard the word.
But the word sown in them was taken away.
Those on good soil began by hearing too; they accepted the word and bore fruit.
In other words, both had the experience of encountering and hearing the Word.

Yet even that can be taken away.

We might think, for example, of hearing a word about forgiveness.
We hear that we should forgive another person and think,
“Perhaps I, too, need to reconsider my relationship with this person.”
But then we set the word aside: “That person is different.”
If we keep setting it aside in the same way,
even the thought we first had—that the Word is speaking to me too—may begin to fade.
“Love your enemies.”
We may still remember the words of Scripture.
And yet we may stop hearing them as a call addressed to us.

Or, following the parable of the sower in Mark 4,
the word we heard may be choked by the cares of life and the desire for wealth.
A word that seemed important when we heard it gets pushed aside amid daily worries,
until we no longer recall it even when making decisions.
Eventually, we may live just as we did before hearing it.

Jesus said to the people listening to him then, “Pay attention.”
Right now, this Word asks us whether we merely think we are listening.
Are we skimming past familiar words?
Even when Jesus is urging us, are we failing to face his words because we think we have no problem?
We need to examine ourselves.

Let us look at this question from another angle.
A little later in the chapter, this is what is written about Jesus and his disciples:

Mark 4:34 He did not speak to them without a parable, but privately he explained everything to his own disciples.

The disciples did not understand all the parables from the beginning.
But they asked Jesus about the parables they did not understand.
And Jesus explained them to the disciples.
Here, what was right was “added” to them.

They were immature in many ways, but one thing can be said:
they loved Jesus and expected much from him. Surely they respected him from their hearts.

They certainly misjudged him at times.

But what did they eventually come to know? Jesus, whom they had measured by their own measure,
was immeasurably greater than they had understood.

They made mistakes, but they were facing the right way as they listened to the Word.

The measure they held was simply too small.

That led them to fail, but because they were facing the right way, in the end they received something
wonderful.

We too need to listen carefully, adjust our measure, and listen rightly.

We need first to hold firmly to who Jesus is and what is in his heart.

Then we begin to see something beyond our understanding.

Of course, because he is God, he cannot fit within our measure.

What should we do then?

We may not understand fully, but we can be sure that the answer is found here,
and listen again to Jesus. This is what it means to be “one who has.”

From this conviction that Jesus is the one who is right, our understanding of the Word grows and our
faith grows deeper. That changes the way we live and changes our lives. Let us cultivate this
continuing movement in the right direction.